



Making the right call

Agent 001 is on a mission to find three very different smartphones for three very different users, on three very different budgets

and a fast processor. I cautioned astronomical prices – my pleas fell on deaf ears. Rossi, being a robotically efficient Quake 3 fragger, had to have an Android phone. Wi-Fi was a must, as was a touchscreen. A QWERTY keypad was necessary as well. His budget was up to Rs. 20,000; slightly upwardly flexible for deserving products. Thus, I had my work cut out for me.

There are a lot of new brands entering the market, but most of these have entry-level options, which is a safe way to “test waters”, rather than going all out with high-end stuff. Google’s Android is a new, exciting platform that includes the OS and supporting applications. It is a platform geared towards online connectivity but there are some pretty basic and glaring flaws – handsfree dialling and call answering support is dodgy. Android’s

latest avatar 2.1 (Éclair) is due in April. Windows Mobile 6.5 is hardly different from WM6 and even WM5 in terms of interface. WM7 is expected to radically change things with native support for capacitive screens and is due in September. Nokia has finally ditched Symbian in favour of Maemo, which, like Android, also borrows its design heavily from Linux.

Usability is what it’s all about:

In terms of handsets, touchscreens are hot and universally desired, although not everybody realises that a flawed design can render a touchscreen phone nigh unusable. Touch designs are resistive

or capacitive, the former being suited for use with pointed objects – stylus, fingernails. Capacitive touch displays work with fingers, and are therefore the more usable of the two. Whether it be for typing out on an on-screen keypad or swiping through menus using gestures and strokes on-screen, capacitive touch displays are the way to go. Anyone who has used an iPhone can testify to its ergonomics – Apple has a flawed handset, but a nearly flawless interface. Sure, HTC has their Touch Flo interface – designed to give WM-based resistive touch devices a semblance a gesture-based interface but this cannot compete with an interface designed from scratch to be touch and gesture based.

The interface of any phone is very important. With high-end handsets, even more so, and this fact is usually overlooked. We get so carried away with 8 megapixel cameras and 16 GB of internal storage that we forget all about convenience of usage, which is everything for a handset in my opinion. Theoretically, if we could choose a handset with all possible interfaces – a hardware QWERTY keypad and touchscreen and maybe a good on-screen number keypad there would be no problem. Practically this is usually costly. Also sometimes, phones that cover all interface options do a shoddy job – a quirky keypad and an interface not designed with gestures in mind would render even a 4-inch capacitive touch-based phone with all the works useless. What I’m trying to say is, the presence of a QWERTY keypad (for instance) doesn’t guarantee a phone will be great for SMS junkies. A large touchscreen phone may be bogged down with slow hardware or even an unintuitive interface. Some phones get it smack on, others flounder. That being said, I’ve loved some quirky handsets in the past – cellphones are so personal, that it’s often

This month, I was at a complete loss at which product group to write about – an unusual situation. But as with everything at Digit, a solution is never far away. Inspiration – three of us, namely Siddharth, Michael and Rossi were looking at purchasing cellphones, though each had different needs. Siddharth could spend Rs. 15,000 and he specifically wanted a QWERTY keypad, a 3.5mm jack, a 2.8-inch display or thereabouts. But a touchscreen was not mandatory. Helpful widgets were a must. Michael craved a touchscreen. He needed a large display, and wanted a good camera and great music playback abilities. Wi-Fi was also desirable, as was adequate memory